Infosys Verbal Ability

Detailed Grammar Rules + Vocabulary + Practice Questions & Answers

How to use this PDF: First learn the rule, then study the examples, and finally attempt the practice set without looking at the answer key.

No.	Chapter
1	Subject–Verb Agreement
2	Tenses
3	Articles & Determiners
4	Prepositions
5	Pronouns
6	Adjectives & Adverbs
7	Conjunctions
8	Modals
9	Conditionals
10	Active & Passive Voice
11	Direct & Indirect Speech
12	Comparison
13	Gerunds & Infinitives
14	Modifiers & Parallelism
15	Common Error Detection Rules
16	Vocabulary – Synonyms
17	Vocabulary – Antonyms
18	Vocabulary – Idioms & Phrases
19	Vocabulary – One Word Substitution
20	Practice Tests + Answer Key

1. Subject–Verb Agreement

Rule 1 – Basic agreement: A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb.

Example: The student works hard. / The students work hard.

Rule 2 – Each/Every: Each, every, everyone, everybody, anyone, someone, nobody, either and neither are generally singular.

Example: Every candidate has an ID. / Neither answer is correct.

Rule 3 – One of: One of + plural noun takes a singular verb.

Example: One of the students is absent.

Rule 4 – A number / The number: A number of + plural verb; the number of + singular verb.

Example: A number of students are absent. / The number of students is rising.

Rule 5 – Either/Neither: With either…or / neither…nor, the verb generally agrees with the nearer subject.

Example: Neither the manager nor the employees are ready.

Rule 6 – As well as / Along with: These expressions do not change the number of the main subject.

Example: The manager, along with his assistants, is present.

Rule 7 – Collective nouns: A collective noun is singular when the group acts as one unit.

Example: The committee has approved the plan.

Rule 8 – Time, money, distance: A single amount treated as one unit usually takes a singular verb.

Example: Ten kilometres is a long distance.

Rule 9 – There is/are: The verb agrees with the real subject after it.

Example: There are many reasons. / There is one reason.

2. Tenses

Present Simple: Use for habits, routines, facts and general truths. Structure: V1 / V1+s.

Example: She works every day. Water boils at 100°C.

Present Continuous: am/is/are + V-ing; action happening now or temporarily.

Example: They are preparing for the exam.

Present Perfect: has/have + V3; completed action with present relevance or unspecified time.

Example: I have finished my work.

Present Perfect Continuous: has/have been + V-ing; action continuing over a period.

Example: She has been studying for three hours.

Past Simple: Completed action at a definite past time.

Example: He visited Pune last week.

Past Continuous: was/were + V-ing; action in progress at a past time.

Example: I was reading when he called.

Past Perfect: had + V3; earlier of two past actions.

Example: The train had left before we arrived.

Past Perfect Continuous: had been + V-ing; ongoing action before another past event.

Example: He had been waiting for an hour before she came.

Future Simple: will + V1; prediction, promise or spontaneous decision.

Example: I will call you tomorrow.

Future Perfect: will have + V3; action completed before a future point.

Example: By Friday, I will have completed the work.

High-frequency trap: After did/did not, use V1. After a modal, use V1.

Example: Did he go? / He can solve it.

3. Articles & Determiners

A / An: Use according to sound, not spelling. A before consonant sound; an before vowel sound.

Example: a university, a European; an hour, an MBA.

The: Use for a specific/known thing, unique things, superlatives, ordinals and certain geographical names.

Example: the sun, the first chapter, the best answer.

No article: Plural or uncountable nouns used generally often take no article.

Example: Books are useful. Milk is nutritious.

Few / A few: Few = almost none; a few = some.

Example: Few students understood it. / A few students understood it.

Little / A little: Little = almost none; a little = some.

Example: There is little hope. / There is a little hope.

Much / Many: Much with uncountable nouns; many with countable nouns.

Example: much information; many questions.

Fewer / Less: Fewer with countable nouns; less with uncountable quantities.

Example: fewer mistakes; less water.

4. Prepositions

At / On / In: At = exact time; on = day/date; in = month/year/long period.

Example: at 8:00, on Monday, in 2026.

Since / For: Since = starting point; for = duration.

Example: since 2020; for six years.

By / Until: By = not later than; until = up to a point in time.

Example: Finish by Friday. / Wait until Friday.

Between / Among: Between is commonly used for two or distinct individuals; among for a group.

Example: between Ravi and Amit; among the students.

In / Into: In often indicates position; into indicates movement to the inside.

Example: He is in the room. / He went into the room.

On / Onto: On indicates position; onto indicates movement to a surface.

Example: The book is on the table. / Put it onto the table.

Fixed combinations: Learn common adjective/verb + preposition combinations.

Example: good at, interested in, depend on, responsible for, capable of, afraid of.

5. Pronouns

Agreement: Pronoun must agree with its antecedent in number and person.

Example: Every student must bring his or her ID.

Subject/object case: Use I/he/she/we/they as subjects; me/him/her/us/them as objects.

Example: She and I went. / The teacher called him and me.

Who/Whom: Who is subject; whom is object in formal usage.

Example: Who called you? / Whom did you meet?

Reflexive pronouns: Use when subject and object are the same, or for emphasis.

Example: She hurt herself. / I myself did it.

Pronoun ambiguity: The pronoun should clearly refer to one noun.

Example: Avoid: Ravi told Amit that he was late.

6. Adjectives & Adverbs

Adjective: Describes a noun/pronoun.

Example: a careful student

Adverb: Modifies a verb, adjective or another adverb.

Example: He writes carefully.

Good / Well: Good is generally an adjective; well is generally an adverb.

Example: She is a good singer. / She sings well.

Hard / Hardly: Hard = with effort; hardly = almost not.

Example: He works hard. / He hardly works.

Late / Lately: Late = not on time; lately = recently.

Example: He arrived late. / Have you seen him lately?

Too / Very: Too often indicates excess; very intensifies.

Example: too difficult to solve; very difficult.

7. Conjunctions

FANBOYS: For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So are coordinating conjunctions.

Example: He studied hard, but he missed the bus.

Correlative conjunctions: either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only...but also.

Example: She is both intelligent and hardworking.

Although / but: Do not normally use although and but together in standard correction questions.

Example: Although it rained, we went out.

Because / so: Do not normally use because and so together for the same causal link.

Example: Because he was late, he missed the bus.

Unless: Unless means if not.

Example: Unless you study, you may not pass.

8. Modals

Can / Could: Can = ability/permission; could = past ability or polite request.

Example: She can swim. / Could you help me?

May / Might: Possibility; might often sounds less certain.

Example: It may rain. / It might rain later.

Must / Should: Must = strong necessity; should = advice/expectation.

Example: You must carry your ID. / You should revise.

Would: Polite requests, preferences, hypothetical situations and some past-future contexts.

Example: Would you help me?

Modal + V1: Never use V2/V3 directly after a modal.

Example: He can solve it, not can solved it.

9. Conditionals

Zero conditional: If + present, present; general truths.

Example: If you heat ice, it melts.

First conditional: If + present, will + V1; real/possible future.

Example: If you study, you will pass.

Second conditional: If + past, would + V1; hypothetical present/future.

Example: If I had time, I would travel.

Third conditional: If + had + V3, would have + V3; unreal past.

Example: If she had studied, she would have passed.

Mixed conditional: A past condition may have a present result.

Example: If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now.

10. Active & Passive Voice

Basic conversion: Object of active becomes subject of passive; use the correct form of be + V3.

Example: The manager approved the plan. → The plan was approved by the manager.

Present simple: am/is/are + V3.

Example: They make cars. → Cars are made.

Past simple: was/were + V3.

Example: She wrote the letter. → The letter was written.

Present perfect: has/have been + V3.

Example: They have completed it. → It has been completed.

Modal: modal + be + V3.

Example: You must follow the rules. → The rules must be followed.

Important: Only transitive verbs normally form passive voice because an object is required.

Example: He slept. → No normal passive form.

11. Direct & Indirect Speech

Statements: With a past reporting verb, tense often shifts back.

Example: He said, “I am busy.” → He said that he was busy.

Common tense shifts: am/is→was; are→were; have/has→had; will→would; can→could.

Example: She said she would come.

Time/place shifts: today→that day; tomorrow→the next day; yesterday→the previous day; now→then; here→there.

Example: He said he would come the next day.

Questions: Use statement word order after the reporting verb.

Example: He asked where I was. (Not where was I.)

Commands: Use told/ordered/asked + object + to + V1.

Example: He said, “Open the door.” → He told me to open the door.

12. Comparison

Positive: as + adjective + as.

Example: Riya is as tall as Neha.

Comparative: -er or more + adjective + than.

Example: This is better than that.

Superlative: -est or most + adjective; normally with 'the'.

Example: She is the most talented student.

Irregular forms: good→better→best; bad→worse→worst; little→less→least; many/much→more→most.

Example: This is the best option.

Avoid double forms: Do not use more better, most easiest, etc.

Example: Correct: much better; easiest.

Prefer: Prefer X to Y.

Example: I prefer tea to coffee.

13. Gerunds & Infinitives

Gerund: V-ing functioning as a noun.

Example: Reading improves vocabulary.

Gerund after preposition: After a preposition, use V-ing.

Example: He is interested in learning.

Verbs followed by gerund: enjoy, avoid, admit, suggest, consider, finish, mind.

Example: She enjoys reading.

Verbs followed by infinitive: want, decide, hope, plan, promise, agree, refuse.

Example: They decided to leave.

Used to: used to + V1 = past habit; be used to + V-ing/noun = accustomed.

Example: I used to play. / I am used to waking early.

Suggest: Suggest + V-ing or suggest that + subject + base verb; not suggest to do.

Example: He suggested taking a break.

14. Modifiers & Parallelism

Modifier placement: Put the modifier close to the word it describes.

Example: Walking home, I saw the rain start. (Not: Walking home, the rain...)

Parallelism: Items joined by and/or or in lists should have the same grammatical form.

Example: She likes reading, writing and speaking.

Correlative parallelism: not only X but also X; either X or X.

Example: He is not only smart but also hardworking.

Dangling modifier: The opening phrase must logically describe the subject that follows.

Example: After finishing the work, Ravi went home.

15. High-Frequency Error Rules

Rule A: One of + plural noun + singular verb.

Example: One of the players is injured.

Rule B: Each of + plural noun + singular verb.

Example: Each of the students has a book.

Rule C: A pair of + singular verb.

Example: A pair of shoes is on the floor.

Rule D: Scarcely/Hardly/Barely ... when; No sooner ... than.

Example: No sooner had he arrived than the meeting began.

Rule E: Between you and me; after a preposition use object form.

Example: This is between you and me.

Rule F: Advice/information/furniture are generally uncountable.

Example: some advice, useful information, new furniture.

Rule G: News is singular.

Example: The news is surprising.

Rule H: Police is generally plural when referring to officers as a group.

Example: The police are investigating.

16. Vocabulary – Synonyms

Word	Synonym	Meaning
Abundant	Plentiful	Available in large quantity
Accurate	Precise	Correct and exact
Brief	Concise	Short and to the point
Cautious	Careful	Avoiding unnecessary risk
Diligent	Hardworking	Showing steady effort
Eloquent	Articulate	Fluent or persuasive in speaking/writing
Feasible	Practical	Possible and workable
Fragile	Delicate	Easily broken/damaged
Genuine	Authentic	Real or genuine
Hostile	Unfriendly	Opposed or aggressive
Inevitable	Unavoidable	Certain to happen
Obsolete	Outdated	No longer in use
Reluctant	Unwilling	Not willing
Rapid	Swift	Very fast
Scarce	Rare	Available in small quantity
Significant	Important	Sufficiently important
Transparent	Clear	Easy to understand or see through
Versatile	Adaptable	Able to perform many functions
Vigilant	Alert	Watchful and careful
Vital	Essential	Extremely important

17. Vocabulary – Antonyms

Word	Antonym
Ancient	Modern
Artificial	Natural
Expand	Contract
Frequent	Rare
Generous	Stingy
Guilty	Innocent
Humble	Arrogant
Include	Exclude
Permanent	Temporary
Rigid	Flexible
Victory	Defeat
Visible	Invisible
Optimistic	Pessimistic
Superior	Inferior
Complex	Simple

18. Idioms & Phrases

Idiom	Meaning
A blessing in disguise	Something that seems bad but turns out beneficial.
Break the ice	Start a friendly conversation or reduce tension.
Hit the nail on the head	Say/do exactly the right thing.
Once in a blue moon	Very rarely.
Piece of cake	Very easy.
Spill the beans	Reveal a secret.
Under the weather	Feeling unwell.
Burn the midnight oil	Work/study late at night.
Bite the bullet	Face a difficult situation bravely.
Call it a day	Stop working for the day.
In hot water	In trouble.
At the eleventh hour	At the last possible moment.

19. One Word Substitution

Description	Word
One who loves books	Bibliophile
One who cannot read or write	Illiterate
One who speaks many languages	Polyglot
A person who knows everything	Omniscient
A place where books are kept	Library
A speech made without preparation	Extempore
A government by the people	Democracy
A person who hates mankind	Misanthrope
A person who looks at the bright side	Optimist
A person who looks at the dark side	Pessimist

20. Practice Test 1 – Grammar

1. Each of the employees ___ required to submit the form.

A) are B) were C) is D) have

2. She did not ___ the email yesterday.

A) sent B) send C) sends D) sending

3. The manager, along with his assistants, ___ attending the meeting.

A) are B) were C) have D) is

4. I have lived here ___ 2020.

A) for B) since C) from D) by

5. He is good ___ mathematics.

A) in B) on C) at D) for

6. If you study hard, you ___ the exam.

A) passed B) would pass C) will pass D) had passed

7. She suggested ___ a break.

A) to take B) taking C) took D) take

8. Neither the teacher nor the students ___ ready.

A) is B) was C) are D) has

9. The work ___ by the team yesterday.

A) completed B) was completed C) is completing D) has complete

10. He asked me where I ___.

A) was B) am C) were D) be

11. This is ___ best solution.

A) a B) an C) the D) no article

12. There ___ many reasons for the delay.

A) is B) are C) was D) has

13. She is senior ___ me.

A) than B) to C) from D) with

14. I am used to ___ early.

A) wake B) waking C) woke D) have wake

15. No sooner had he arrived ___ the meeting began.

A) when B) then C) than D) but

16. A number of students ___ absent today.

A) is B) are C) was D) has

17. The number of applicants ___ increasing.

A) are B) were C) is D) have

18. She sings very ___.

A) good B) well C) betterly D) best

19. If I had known, I ___ helped you.

A) will have B) would have C) would D) had

20. Between you and ___, this plan needs improvement.

A) I B) myself C) me D) mine

Practice Test 2 – Vocabulary

21. Choose the synonym of Diligent.

A) Lazy B) Hardworking C) Careless D) Weak

22. Choose the antonym of Scarce.

A) Rare B) Limited C) Abundant D) Small

23. 'Break the ice' means:

A) Become angry B) Start a friendly interaction C) End a meeting D) Create a problem

24. A person who loves books is called a:

A) Bibliophile B) Misanthrope C) Polyglot D) Optimist

25. Choose the synonym of Feasible.

A) Impossible B) Practical C) Uncertain D) Dangerous

26. Choose the antonym of Rigid.

A) Strict B) Hard C) Flexible D) Fixed

27. 'At the eleventh hour' means:

A) Very early B) At the last moment C) At noon D) After eleven days

28. Choose the synonym of Vigilant.

A) Alert B) Sleepy C) Confused D) Careless

29. A person who speaks many languages is a:

A) Linguist B) Polyglot C) Bibliophile D) Novice

30. 'Spill the beans' means:

A) Waste food B) Reveal a secret C) Make a mistake D) Work hard

Answer Key & Explanations

Q	Ans.	Why?
1	C	Each is singular → is.
2	B	After did not, use V1 → send.
3	D	Main subject is manager; along with does not change it.
4	B	Since + starting point.
5	C	Correct combination: good at.
6	C	First conditional: if + present, will + V1.
7	B	Suggest is followed by V-ing or that-clause.
8	C	Verb agrees with nearer subject: students.
9	B	Past passive: was + V3.
10	A	Indirect question uses statement order: where I was.
11	C	Superlative normally takes the.
12	B	Real subject is reasons → are.
13	B	Correct expression: senior to.
14	B	Be used to + gerund/noun.
15	C	No sooner…than.
16	B	A number of + plural verb.
17	C	The number of + singular verb.
18	B	Well modifies the verb sings.
19	B	Third conditional: would have + V3.
20	C	Preposition between requires object form me.
21	B	Diligent = hardworking.
22	C	Scarce = limited; antonym = abundant.
23	B	Break the ice = start a friendly interaction.
24	A	Bibliophile = book lover.
25	B	Feasible = practical/possible.
26	C	Rigid = inflexible; antonym = flexible.
27	B	At the eleventh hour = at the last moment.
28	A	Vigilant = alert/watchful.
29	B	Polyglot = person who speaks many languages.
30	B	Spill the beans = reveal a secret.

Final Revision Strategy: Master subject–verb agreement, tense usage, articles, prepositions, pronouns, conditionals and sentence correction first. Then revise high-frequency vocabulary every day using synonym/antonym pairs, idioms and one-word substitutions. In practice, identify the grammar rule before selecting an option.